
Seek Wander

Implementation Roadmap & Backlog

Engineering & Business Execution Plan

Classification: Confidential — ZenithAI Data Room

Document Version: 1.0

Last Updated: March 2026

STRATEGY STATUS: ACTIVE

Native Affiliate Pivot

Primary monetization strategy pivoted from Stripe paywall to native affiliate placements. Free product, backend revenue capture on booking events.

1

Security & Infrastructure Stability

Protects Anthropic margins from abuse before any growth activity



[IMMEDIATE] Deploy before any marketing or growth activity

1.1

Upstash Redis Rate Limiting

- Install @upstash/ratelimit and @upstash/redis packages
- Create Upstash Redis database at console.upstash.com — copy REST URL + token to env vars
- Implement sliding-window rate limiter in src/app/api/itinerary/route.ts:
 - Authenticated users: 5 generations / hour keyed by Clerk userId
 - Unauthenticated users: 2 generations / hour keyed by IP address (x-forwarded-for)
- Return 429 Too Many Requests with Retry-After header on limit breach
- Add UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_URL and UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_TOKEN to Vercel environment variables

TECHNICAL IMPLEMENTATION

```
// src/app/api/itinerary/route.ts
import { Ratelimit } from "@upstash/ratelimit";
import { Redis } from "@upstash/redis";

const ratelimit = new Ratelimit({
  redis: Redis.fromEnv(),
  limiter: Ratelimit.slidingWindow(5, "1 h"),
  analytics: true,
});

const identifier = userId ?? request.headers.get("x-forwarded-for") ?? "anonymous";
const { success, reset } = await ratelimit.limit(identifier);
if (!success) {
  return Response.json({ error: "Rate limit exceeded" }, {
    status: 429,
    headers: { "Retry-After": String(Math.ceil((reset - Date.now()) / 1000)) }
  });
}
```

Why this matters: Without rate limiting, a single malicious actor can drain \$50+ of Anthropic credits in minutes. This is the most critical infrastructure gap before any marketing or growth activity.

1.2

AI JSON Error Handling (Retry + Fix Prompt)

- Wrap JSON.parse(aiResponse) in a try/catch inside src/app/api/itinerary/route.ts
- On parse failure, trigger a secondary 'fix' prompt to Claude:
 - Pass the malformed output back to the model
 - Instruct it to return only the corrected, valid JSON
- If the fix prompt also fails, return a user-friendly 503 error (never expose raw AI output)

- Log both failures to server console with destination + token counts for monitoring

TECHNICAL IMPLEMENTATION

```
let itinerary: ItineraryResponse;
try {
  itinerary = JSON.parse(rawContent);
} catch {
  // Secondary 'fix' prompt
  const fixResponse = await client.messages.create({
    model: "claude-sonnet-4-6",
    max_tokens: 8192,
    system: "You are a JSON repair tool. Return only valid JSON, nothing else.",
    messages: [{ role: "user", content: `Fix this malformed JSON:\n\n${rawContent}` } ]
  });
  try {
    itinerary = JSON.parse(fixResponse.content[0].text);
  } catch {
    return Response.json({ error: "Generation failed. Please try again." }, { status: 503 });
  }
}
```

Why this matters: Claude produces valid JSON >99% of the time, but network interruptions, token truncation, or edge-case destinations can cause malformed output. Without a retry, users see a broken experience with no path to recovery.

2

Core User Experience & Polish

Retention infrastructure before growth spend

[HIGH] Implement before significant user acquisition begins

2.1

Empty State UX (/trips)

- Detect `trips.length === 0` in `src/app/trips/page.tsx` (server component — no client JS needed)
- Design full-page editorial empty state matching the Million-Dollar Aesthetic:
 - Large Cormorant Garamond italic heading: "Your journeys begin here."
 - DM Sans body copy: "Every curated itinerary you generate is archived here..."
 - Single burnt-orange CTA button → / (the curation form)
 - Optional: Framer Motion fade-in-up animation on the empty state container
- Ensure `print:hidden` is applied so the empty state never appears in PDF exports

Design reference: Match the visual language of the custom not-found.tsx page — centered, generous whitespace, serif heading, single clear action.

3

Primary Monetization: Native Affiliate Placements

Primary revenue engine — implement before significant user growth

[HIGH] Primary revenue engine — implement before significant user growth

3.1

Affiliate Link Injection System

- Register affiliate accounts:
 - Booking.com Partner Programme (hotels): `partners.booking.com`
 - Viator Partner Programme (tours & experiences): `partner.viator.com`
 - GetYourGuide Affiliate (activities): `getyourguide.com/partner`
 - OpenTable (restaurant reservations): `opentable.com/affiliate`
- Build affiliate URL resolver at `src/lib/affiliateLinks.ts`:
 - Input: `TimelineItem` (type, title, destination)
 - Output: affiliate URL with tracking parameters or null if no match
 - Map type === 'activity' → Viator / GetYourGuide deep link
 - Map type === 'breakfast' | 'lunch' | 'dinner' → OpenTable reservation link
 - Map hotel mentions in description → Booking.com search link
- Inject links into `TimelineCard` in `ItineraryViewer.tsx`:
 - Activity/meal cards: add subtle "Book Now" text link (DM Sans, text-ink-light)
 - Link opens in `target=_blank rel=noopener noreferrer sponsored`
- UTM parameter strategy: append
 - `?utm_source=seekwander&utm_medium=itinerary&utm_campaign={destination}`

- Add affiliate disclosure to /shared/[id] page footer (required by FTC + affiliate program TOS)

Platform	Commission Type	Est. Rate
Booking.com	% of hotel booking value	4-6%
Viator	% of tour booking value	8%
GetYourGuide	% of activity value	8-10%
OpenTable	Per-cover fee	\$1-2/cover

Why native, not banner: The product's luxury positioning is its primary differentiator. A 'Book on Booking.com' text link styled in ink-light is invisible as advertising. A banner ad destroys the Vogue aesthetic and the trust that drives conversions.

4

Zero-CAC Growth & Operations (n8n Automations)

Build after affiliate infrastructure is live and generating revenue signals



[MEDIUM] Build after affiliate infrastructure is live and generating revenue signals

4.1

Automated Social Content Engine

- Vercel Cron trigger: Add GET /api/cron/social to vercel.json — schedule: 0 9 * * * (09:00 UTC daily)
- n8n workflow design:
 - Webhook node receives trigger from Vercel Cron (secured with SOCIAL_CRON_SECRET)
 - Supabase node queries most-generated destination in last 7 days from CostLog
 - Anthropic node generates editorial caption (<=280 chars, no hashtags, Vogue tone)
 - HTTP Request node posts to Pinterest Boards API + Twitter/X API v2
 - Error handler node sends Slack/email alert on failure
- Store N8N_WEBHOOK_URL and SOCIAL_CRON_SECRET in Vercel environment variables
- Create n8n instance at cloud.n8n.io (free tier sufficient for this volume)

Zero-CAC thesis: Every AI-generated social post is a free acquisition touchpoint. A single viral Pinterest pin of a '7-Day Amalfi Coast Itinerary' can drive hundreds of organic sign-ups with zero ad spend.

4.2

White-Glove Founder's Welcome Email

- Clerk webhook setup: Dashboard → Webhooks → Add endpoint → POST /api/webhooks/clerk
 - Subscribe to user.created event
 - Copy Webhook Secret to CLERK_WEBHOOK_SECRET env var
- Webhook route at src/app/api/webhooks/clerk/route.ts:
 - Verify signature using svix package (Clerk's webhook verification library)
 - Extract email_address and first_name from payload
 - POST to n8n webhook with user data + 10-minute delay instruction
- n8n workflow: Wait 10 minutes → Send Email via Resend or Postmark
 - From: roman@seekwander.com (personal, not noreply)
 - Subject: 'Your first journey' — plain text, no HTML, no logo

EMAIL TEMPLATE (PLAIN TEXT — NO HTML)

Hi [first_name],

I wanted to reach out personally. You just used Seek Wander to plan your first trip – and I'm genuinely grateful.

Seek Wander isn't an algorithm. Every itinerary is curated with the same care a private travel consultant would give a long-standing client.

If you have feedback, questions, or a dream destination you want me to know about – just reply here. I read every email.

Warmly,
Roman
Founder, Seek Wander

Why this converts: Plain-text founder emails sent 10 minutes after sign-up consistently achieve 60-80% open rates. This is the highest-leverage retention touchpoint in the entire stack.

5

Legal & Compliance

Required for affiliate programme approvals and general liability



[MEDIUM] Required before affiliate programme applications can be submitted

5.1

Terms of Service & Privacy Policy

- Generate legal pages using Termly.io or iubenda configured for:
 - Affiliate link disclosure (FTC compliance)
 - Cookie usage (Clerk session cookies, Google Maps)
 - Data retention policy (trips stored until user deletion request)
 - AI-generated content disclaimer
- Create routes:
 - src/app/legal/terms/page.tsx — Terms of Service
 - src/app/legal/privacy/page.tsx — Privacy Policy
 - Both: server components, export const dynamic = 'force-dynamic', Seek Wander aesthetic
- Add footer links: 'Terms · Privacy · (c) 2026 Seek Wander'
- Affiliate disclosure banner on ItineraryViewer.tsx and /shared/[id]

Why this is a blocker: Booking.com, Viator, and GetYourGuide all require a Privacy Policy URL at affiliate application time. This must be live before submitting applications.

6

Future Expansion (Deprioritized)

Optionality — implement only if affiliate revenue is insufficient



[LOW] Deprioritized — implement only if affiliate revenue is insufficient

6.1

Stripe Paywall (\$4.99 Transactional Gate)

- Add UserBalance Prisma model (run prisma db push)
- Install Stripe: npm install stripe @stripe/stripe-js
- Checkout session route at src/app/api/stripe/checkout/route.ts:
 - Creates Stripe Checkout session for \$4.99 one-time payment
 - success_url → /itinerary?session_id={CHECKOUT_SESSION_ID}
 - cancel_url → /
- Webhook fulfillment at src/app/api/webhooks/stripe/route.ts:
 - Verify Stripe webhook signature
 - On checkout.session.completed: increment paidCredits
- Gate itinerary generation in route.ts — check free + paid credit balance
- Paywall UI in CurationForm.tsx — burnt-orange 'Unlock for \$4.99' button

- Add env vars: STRIPE_SECRET_KEY, NEXT_PUBLIC_STRIPE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY, STRIPE_WEBHOOK_SECRET

Deprioritization rationale: The affiliate model has higher lifetime value per user with zero conversion friction. A \$4.99 gate reduces top-of-funnel conversion by an estimated 60-80% at the pre-brand-awareness stage. This feature is preserved as an option — not abandoned.



Backlog Summary

All tasks, priorities, and current status

#	Task	Phase	Priority	Status
1.1	Upstash Redis Rate Limiting	Infrastructure	[IMMEDIATE]	Pending
1.2	AI JSON Error Handling	Infrastructure	[IMMEDIATE]	Pending
2.1	Empty State UX (/trips)	UX Polish	[HIGH]	Pending
3.1	Affiliate Link Injection	Monetization	[HIGH]	Pending
4.1	Automated Social Engine (n8n)	Growth	[MEDIUM]	Pending
4.2	Founder's Welcome Email (n8n)	Growth	[MEDIUM]	Pending
5.1	Terms of Service & Privacy	Legal	[MEDIUM]	Pending
6.1	Stripe Paywall (\$4.99)	Monetization	[LOW]	Pending

Priority Legend

Label	Meaning	Action Required
[IMMEDIATE]	Critical infrastructure gap — deploy before growth	This sprint
[HIGH]	Revenue-impacting or retention-critical	Next sprint
[MEDIUM]	Important but not blocking revenue	This quarter
[LOW]	Optionality — deprioritized	Backlog

This document is a living backlog. Update task statuses and add sub-tasks as implementation progresses. Sync with CLAUDE.md when any item reaches production.